

Chronology

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Three timelines run through this volume and it helps to keep them apart: the Egyptian one, which is deep and imprecise; the classical one, which supplies the Roman comparison; and the modern one, in which the games were dug up, described, and — by Falkener — reconstructed. Egyptian dates are approximate and are given as such.

c. 3300–2200 BC	The span of the spiral game — mehen, Falkener’s game of the bowl. The earliest boards are Predynastic (Naqada II), and the game runs through the third to sixth dynasties. Its best surviving evidence is a painted scene in the tomb of Hesy-Ra at Saqqara, c. 2650 BC, which shows the board with the marbles and the lion-shaped pieces that went with it. It is the leading candidate for the oldest board game known.
c. 2600–2500 BC	The fourth dynasty, to which Falkener traces the draughts-like games. He declines to put a year on it and leaves the chronology to specialists.
c. 1900 BC	The twelfth-dynasty tombs at Beni-Hassan, whose painted scenes Birch describes game by game: the low table of painted wood, the twelve men, the players each lifting a piece.
c. 1479–1458 BC	The reign of Queen Hatasu — Hatshepsut — whose draught-board Falkener describes in section III. The 1887 exhibition label he quotes dates the relics to 1600 BC and calls them the work of “royal artists 3,500 years ago”; modern chronology puts her reign a century and a half later than that. The error is the label’s, not Falkener’s, and it is a fair measure of how much Egyptian dating moved after him.
c. 450 BC	Herodotus, cited by Birch on Rhampsinitus, and the earliest Greek writer to report Egyptian gaming as a matter of course.
1st c. BC – 2nd c. AD	The Latin poets on the ludus latrunculorum, and the period from which most of what is known about the Roman game comes — descriptions of pieces blocked and surrounded, never a statement of the rules.
AD 100	The date <i>Falkener</i> gives for the illustration on the 1892 book’s back cover, which he takes for the time of Trajan. It is not a date this edition endorses: the lion-and-gazelle papyrus he is describing is Ramesside, roughly 1250–1150 BC, some thirteen centuries earlier. The row is here because the book prints the claim, and a volume whose job is marking where he is wrong should not adopt his dating in its own chronology.
1620–1694	Salmasius, Souterius, Bulengerus, Severinus, Hyde. The antiquarian scholarship that assembled every classical passage on ancient games and stopped there — the shelf Falkener says produced a skeleton and no living game.
1801–1869	Christie, Becker, van Oppen, Coleridge, Becq de Fouquières. The nineteenth-century continuation of the same effort, and Falkener’s immediate predecessors.
1 April 1864	Dr Samuel Birch writes the paper on the Egyptian gaming scenes that Falkener prints in section II. It is the earliest thing in the volume by date of composition and the most reliable.
1870	Birch founds the Society of Biblical Archaeology and becomes its president — six years after the letter, which is worth noting because Falkener describes him by the later office.
1885	Birch dies, which is why Falkener calls him <i>the late Dr Birch</i> .
3 May 1887	The Royal Jubilee Exhibition opens in Manchester, marking Victoria’s golden jubilee. The Egyptian relics Falkener describes in section III were shown there by their owner Jesse Haworth, the Manchester cotton merchant who funded Flinders Petrie’s excavations. It is the single event that dates section III, and therefore the book.
1892	<i>Games Ancient and Oriental, and How to Play Them</i> published in London by Longmans, Green and Co. The first serious attempt to state playable rules for the ancient games rather than only to collect the evidence for them.
1896	Edward Falkener dies, on 17 December, at Laugharne. His work is in the public domain everywhere. The exact route is worth stating rather than compressing: the 1892 imprint is pre-1931, which settles the United States; in the United Kingdom the term ran life-plus-fifty until 1996, so his work was already free there long before the life-plus-seventy rule arrived, and it stayed free when it did.
20th c.	Senet is reconstructed again, by Timothy Kendall in 1978 and Peter Piccione in 1980, on the same absence of a rulebook Falkener faced. Those versions are the ones most often printed today. They rest on evidence spanning more than a thousand years of play, they disagree with their predecessors on basic points — H. J. R. Murray, writing in 1952, read the marked squares as where pieces enter, and Kendall as where they leave — and none of them is the ancient rules either.

